

Participant Guide

Secondary Education

This guide is yours. It holds a short summary of each session and every activity you will work on across the day.

Name (optional)

School

Welcome

Across today you will build a broad, mixed picture of Autistic experience, then turn it into one practical change to a lesson, assessment task or handover, and one purposeful conversation with a family, a student or a colleague.

How to use this guide

- Each session opens with a one-page summary of the key ideas.
- Activity pages follow, ready to write on. Some are done alone, some with a partner, a trio or a small group.
- Keep two or three real students in mind all day. Choose students who differ from each other.
- Use initials or roles only. Nothing in this guide should identify a student, family or colleague.

The day at a glance

Time	Session	
8:30 - 9:45	1	The Lens
9:45 - 10:45	2	Understanding Autistic Experience: Sensory and Thinking
10:45 - 11:00		<i>Morning tea</i>
11:00 - 12:30	3	Autistic Experience at Secondary School
12:30 - 1:00		<i>Lunch</i>
1:00 - 2:15	4	Learning Design
2:15 - 3:15	5	Working in Partnership
3:15 - 4:00	6	Flourishing & Full Circle

The thread through the day

A few pages carry forward from session to session. Look for these:

Session 1	Think about your students and My starting point
Session 3	Secondary day map, audit and Carry into design card
Session 4	Our design, My students check and Commit
Session 5	Bridge to the next family conversation
Session 6	Start · Continue · Reconsider and Plan the next conversation

Key ideas

Neurodiversity and neurodivergence

Neurodiversity is the whole picture. Neurotypical and neurodivergent describe brain patterns within neurodiversity. Autism is one expression of that diversity.

A neurodiversity-affirming approach

- Acknowledging different ways of knowing, doing, being and belonging
- All people have strengths and experience challenges
- Differences are not deficits
- There is no right or wrong way to think, learn or behave
- Everyone experiences and interacts with the world differently

The social model

Use an environment-first lens: look for barriers in places, tasks, routines and expectations; ask what can change around the student; include the student's communication and experience; review whether the change makes participation more workable.

Autism as difference · Dynamic disability

A student's access and support needs may change with the task, environment, relationships and available capacity.

ACTIVITY**Think about your students** On your own

Bring two or three students to mind, ideally students who are quite different from each other. You will return to them all day.

Student	Strengths, interests or moments of connection that should stay visible
Student A	
Student B	
Student C	

Use initials or roles only. No names or identifying details.

What are you here for?	What would you like to understand better?

ACTIVITY**What did you notice?** After the student voice video

What stayed with you?	What would you like to understand more deeply?

ACTIVITY**Look again at school** Small groups

School routines reflect ideas about participation and learning. Consider:

- **What is school for?**
- **Who is school for?**
- **How do students learn?**
- **Whose ways of communicating, moving and participating are treated as expected?**

Choose one familiar routine or decision

Which assumptions shape it?

Who can access it easily?

Where might the environment create a barrier?

How could curiosity change the next response?

Discuss systems and routines, not identifiable students or colleagues.

ACTIVITY**My starting point** You will return to this in Session 6

What is school for?

In your own words, this morning

What am I curious about today?

Questions you hope the day will help with

Understanding Autistic Experience

Sensory and Thinking

Key ideas

Sensory processing

Sensory processing is the way the brain receives, processes and responds to information from the senses. There are eight senses, not five: touch, vision, taste, hearing and smell, plus proprioception (body in space), vestibular (balance and movement) and interoception (internal body signals). How the brain responds is not a choice.

Winnie Dunn's framework describes four patterns of sensory response: registration, seeking, sensitive and avoiding. A student can show different patterns in different senses, and patterns shift with load and context.

Sensory joy and stimming

Sensory experience can include pleasure, connection and regulation as well as discomfort or overload. Notice sensory joy, recognise stimming as authentic expression, and avoid treating difference as disruption by default.

Autistic thinking

- Detail-first (bottom-up) processing: noticing details before building the whole picture, with real strengths in pattern recognition and precision.
- Deep focus (monotropism): attention channelled fully into fewer things, supporting learning and flow; shifting attention takes time and warning.
- Executive functioning: planning, organisation, time management, working memory, meta-cognition, emotional regulation, flexibility, attention, task initiation and persistence.

Internal signals

Interoception is noticing and interpreting body signals. Alexithymia is difficulty identifying and describing emotions. Internal experience may not be visible, so reading early signs together helps everyone respond more consistently.

Choose one familiar classroom routine. What sensory demands does the environment or task create, and what options could increase access or choice?

Routine:

Sensory demand (environment or task)	Option that could increase access or choice	Question to explore
1		
2		
3		
4		

ACTIVITY**Strengths I can see** On your own

Detail-first thinking produces genuine strengths. What strengths do you see in the students you have in mind, and where do they show up?

Student	Strengths I have seen	Where or when I see them
Student A		
Student B		
Student C		

Be specific: what does each strength look like in your classroom?

ACTIVITY**Thinking discussion** Pairs

What deep interests do the students you have in mind have?

What do you notice when they are fully engaged, and does it look the same for each of them?

When during the school day do they have trouble getting started or shifting their attention?

Have you seen any of them fully absorbed in something at school? What were they doing?

What signs might you notice at school before one of these students becomes overwhelmed?

Student	Signs I might notice at school before overwhelm
Student A	
Student B	
Student C	

What would be useful for other staff and families to know about these signs?	Are the signs the same for each student?

Autistic Experience at Secondary School

Communication, Connection and Identity

Key ideas

Communication is multimodal

Speech is one part of communication. How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand. AAC (augmentative and alternative communication) is part of communication access and needs to be available where communication happens.

Supporting communication

Clear communication (familiar words, one idea or step at a time), processing time, and visual supports (showing information as well as saying it). The right support depends on the person and the moment.

Double empathy and connection

Misunderstanding can happen in both directions between people with different experiences and communication styles. Connection does not need to look one way, and can happen with family, at school, in the community and online.

Managing daily capacity

Think of a student's energy as a battery, or a set of spoons. Every day starts with a different charge; every action uses some; the right supports can recharge it. Capacity fluctuates from day to day.

Masking, identity and belonging

What is visible does not tell the whole story. A student may be working hard to appear "fine". A young person who knows who they are, and feels genuinely valued for it, has more available for everything else.

Six classrooms, six teachers, one student

Every period change brings a new room, adult, set of expectations and sensory setting. Each teacher sees one part of the day. Sharing what works across those teachers is something a school can plan for.

Masking in the teenage years

The pressure to fit in is often highest in the secondary years, and masking often increases. Burnout and School Can't can build up over time. It is also a time of growth: young people can build self-understanding and self-advocacy when school feels safe.

ACTIVITY
Who is part of the communication network? On your own

Put one of the students you have in mind in the centre. Add one person or place now; you can return to the rest later.

Home family, carers, pets	Friends in person or online	Teachers across subjects, relief
Community sport, clubs, shops	Student	Support staff learning support, wellbeing
Which parts of this network do I know little about? These are questions to explore with the student and their family 		

ACTIVITY
What should travel between people and places? Post-it notes

A communication strength Purple note	What helps communication Blue note	What I would like others to know Orange note

Think about relief teachers, other subject teachers, staff on duty at recess and lunch, and home. What should travel so the student does not have to start again with every new person?

ACTIVITY**Connection discussion** Pairs

Where do the students you have in mind spend recess and lunch, and who with?

What kinds of connection does each of them enjoy? (Shared interests, gaming, sport, music, clubs, online communities, being together quietly?)

Which parts of the day are socially hardest for them: group work, corridors, the canteen, PE?

What could teachers change to make connection easier, without putting them on the spot?

ACTIVITY**Masking discussion** Pairs

Which classes, teachers or times of day ask the most of them to appear "fine"?

Where at school do they seem most able to be themselves?

Who would notice if they were struggling, and how would that reach the right people?

Use a real timetable for one of your students, or the sample Year 9 timetable. Go period by period. For each student, note what the period asks of them and whether anything gives energy back.

Mark: **C** costs energy **L** lightens or gives energy back **?** not sure yet

Period	Room, teacher, what happens	Student A	Student B	Student C
Arrival				
Period 1				
Period 2				
Recess				
Period 3				
Period 4				
Lunch				
Period 5				
Period 6				
Departure				

The map is a working picture to extend, not a judgement of the student or school.

Costs

What adds demand or uncertainty?

Lightens

What reduces demand? What restores capacity or brings joy?

Where is a student's experience unknown?

Choose one to audit: how instructions are given · assessment notice · corridors and lockers · relief-teacher arrangements · where a student can regulate between periods.

Choose one part of the day that runs across classes. What may its impact be, and why?

1 Name the setting or process.

2 Write what educators can observe without interpretation.

3 List possible environmental or task contributors.

4 Record what lightens demand and one question to investigate.

Choose from your secondary day map and audit.

Keep

One practice to keep because it supports access, connection or joy

Reduce

Bring this to Session 4

One barrier or unnecessary demand to reduce

It is a: ☐ lesson ☐ assessment task ☐ handover

Explore

One question to explore with students, families or the team

Learning Design

Redesigning a lesson, task or handover, tested against real students

Key ideas

Students come first

Move from understanding to design without turning students into a list of problems. Start with the real students you have in mind, a specific access question and evidence from your secondary day map and audit.

Design the change, then check it

This session designs one change to a lesson, an assessment task or a handover. You design it universally first, then check it against each of your students.

Options to draw on

- Executive functioning meets assessment: publish schedules early, chunk tasks with visible milestones, show an exemplar and make submission steps literal.
- Predictability across the timetable: clear information about routine and change, in every class and on relief days. Predictability is access to information, not a promise that nothing will change.
- Supports that travel: a one-page profile, written with the student and shared with every teacher, including relief teachers.
- Visual supports: clarify what students need to find, understand, remember or communicate.

Universal first, then the continuum

Universal Design for Learning offers more than one way to access, engage and respond. Where a design still doesn't work for someone, support continues along a continuum: inclusive environment, universal supports, targeted supports, then individual adjustments, recorded through NCCD processes.

ACTIVITY**Our brief** Trios · agree on one lesson, task or handover you all recognise

Our focus (a lesson, task or handover):

It is a: ☐ lesson ☐ assessment task ☐ handover

This asks students to...

For some students, that means...

We could change...

☐ Specific, workable, and free from blame or deficit labels

ACTIVITY**Options we chose** Trios

- ☐ Executive functioning meets assessment
- ☐ Predictability across the timetable
- ☐ Supports that travel
- ☐ Visual supports
- ☐ Something else

Why it fits: which demand in our design does it answer?

ACTIVITY**Universal first** Trios · run these over your draft

- ☐ Can students find and understand what they need?
- ☐ Can they take part in more than one way?
- ☐ Can they pause, ask for help or recover?
- ☐ Is the support available when demand increases?
- ☐ Is there more than one way to access, engage and respond?

What we adjusted:

ACTIVITY**Quick review of a visual support** If your design uses one

- ☐ Can the student understand it?
- ☐ Can they access it when they need it?
- ☐ Does it reflect what is actually happening, including change?
- ☐ Does it provide useful information or a way to respond?

1 The barrier or unnecessary demand

2 The change to the environment, task or routine

3 How students' communication and experience are included

4 What we will observe

5 When we will review it

☐ Checked by another trio: still student-centred and environment-first

ACTIVITY**My students check** On your own · private

Hold your trio's design up against each of the students you have in mind.

	Helps	No difference	Needs something more
Student A			
Student B			
Student C			

Where the design still doesn't work for someone, that is where targeted or individual support begins.

ACTIVITY**Commit** After the gallery walk

This week, in my own classes	With my faculty or year level team	To raise with school leaders

Who I will involve Including the student and family	How students and families will help refine it

Working in Partnership

Who should I involve in this journey?

Key ideas

Where partnerships converge

Students, families, teachers and support staff each bring different knowledge and a different relationship with the student. The student is at the centre of every partnership, and the skills that make partnership work are shared across all of them.

Effective collaboration

Shared goals · shared values · mutual trust and respect · consulting on decision-making · seeing other perspectives · inviting curiosity · centring student voice · assuming good intent.

Power dynamics

Power can sit in socio-economic status, historical and cultural experiences of education, language, understanding of school systems, and the perceived importance of school. It is also present in meeting structures, language and decision pathways.

Consultation literacy

Useful consultation has a clear shared purpose, open questions, more than one way to contribute, respect for student and family knowledge, accurate recording and an agreed action with follow-up. Ask, listen, and follow up.

Adolescents in their own meetings

Move from talking about students to having them take part and, over time, lead their own meetings. Speaking up for themselves now is practice for senior school, work and life after school.

When student capacity runs out

Meltdown, shutdown and School Can't are discussed without blame. Home and school may observe different parts of the student's experience. Focus on safety, what preceded the situation, what supports recovery and what can change.

ACTIVITY**Power dynamics** Post-it notes · 6 minutes

An imbalance from a home perspective	An imbalance from a school perspective	How I could address these imbalances

ACTIVITY**Student voice** After the video

What decisions were made, and who made them?	What impact did those decisions have on Adon?	How are the students I have in mind asked and heard?

ACTIVITY
Partnership activity Table groups · 8 minutes

For each partner: what do they bring, and what challenges might they face?

Partner	Brings	Challenges
Student		
Parents and carers		
Subject teachers		
Year level and support staff		

What do all four have in common?

ACTIVITY
The first two minutes Pairs · 6 minutes

One of you is the teacher, the other plays a parent or a student. For two minutes, only ask and listen back. No solving yet. Then swap.

Scenario 1 A parent: "My son in Year 8 has come home upset every afternoon this week. He won't say why, but he mentioned Science."

Scenario 2 A parent: "My daughter has stopped handing in homework. She says she doesn't know what the teachers want."

Scenario 3 A Year 10 student, asked to a meeting about adjustments for assessments, who isn't sure they want anyone to know.

What did asking first bring out?	What made it hard not to jump to solutions?	A question I will use to open

ACTIVITY**Consultation checklist** For your next meeting

- ☐ A clear, shared purpose
- ☐ Open questions
- ☐ More than one way to contribute
- ☐ Respect for student and family knowledge
- ☐ Accurate recording of what was heard
- ☐ An agreed action, responsibility and follow-up

ACTIVITY**Bridge to the next family conversation** On your own · bring this to Session 6

Prepare for one purposeful conversation.

What needs to be understood?

What question will open the conversation?

How will the student take part, or have their views included?

What can be decided together?

How and when will the school follow up?

Flourishing & Full Circle

One change, one purposeful conversation

Key ideas

Belonging, capacity and joy

- Belonging: being recognised, included and able to participate as oneself.
- Capacity: what the day costs, protects and restores.
- Joy: interests, connection and authentic expression.

Return to these when judging whether a change supports flourishing.

Bringing the day together

A neurodiversity-affirming lens that begins with the person; a more accessible classroom shaped by student experience; and positive partnership that brings student, family and school knowledge together.

ACTIVITY

Bringing it all together

Table groups · 8 minutes

The strongest thing I'm taking back to my school	Our table's three ideas most worth spreading	Who needs to hear each one, and in which meeting or moment?

Start

One strategy to start, something small you can start next week

Continue

One practice to continue, something today confirmed you already do well

Reconsider

One approach to reconsider, something you would now do differently

How will I know it worked?	What evidence will show it?

This card is yours. Share one thing on it with someone at your table. Your Session 4 "this week" change can be your Start.

Choose the real conversation you'll have within two weeks, with a student's family, the student themselves, or a colleague who teaches them.

What I'll share A strength first	What I'll ask Specifically	What I'll offer

My opening sentence, word for word

When	Where	How

Turn back to "My starting point" in Session 1. Read your own words. What's different now?

Where was I this morning?	Where am I now?

What will I do differently in my teaching?

Answer it in one sentence, for yourself.

Connections that continue

Today is a starting point. These supports continue after the workshop.

Webinars and deep dives	Follow-ups on UDL, executive functioning, sensory design, anxiety and more. [Titles, dates and links to confirm]
Online Community of Practice	A place to keep talking with other educators after today. [Link or QR code to add]
Positive Partnerships	positivepartnerships.com.au
Visual Supports Checklist	A practical resource for reviewing an existing support or planning a new one. [Where to find it, to confirm]
NCCD	NCCD Meetings Tool Kit and current official NCCD information: nccd.edu.au
Disability Standards for Education	Getting started; Advocating with and for your child; Milestones and transitions (Department of Education)
Autism Connect	National autism helpline: 1300 308 699
Disability Gateway	1800 643 787
Carer Gateway	Emotional, practical and financial support for carers: 1800 422 737

My notes
